

UNIT-4

STRESS MANAGEMENT

Psychology of Stress

Stress: It's a four-letter word that many of us dread. Whether it's a tense interaction with a boss or pressure from friends and family, we all face stressful situations from time to time.

For some of us, these events happen sporadically. For others, daily stress is a regular part of life.

There's a good chance we can all identify negative stress, but did you know that stress can also be positive?

Good stress, called eustress, can actually be beneficial to you. Unlike bad stress, or distress, good stress can help with motivation, focus, energy, and performance. For some people, it can also feel exciting.

On the other hand, bad stress typically causes anxiety, concern, and a decrease in performance. It also feels uncomfortable, and it can lead to more serious issues if not addressed.

Psychological stress effects

It's no secret that the long-term effects of distress can damage our health Trusted Source.

Stress has the ability to negatively impact our lives. It can cause physical conditions, such as headaches, digestive issues, and sleep disturbances. It can also cause psychological and emotional strains, including confusion, anxiety, and depression.

According to the American Psychological Association, untreated chronic stress, or stress that's constant and lasts over an extended period of time, can result in high blood pressure or a weakened immune system.

There's a distinction between a stressor and actual stress. A stressor can be a person, place, or situation that's causing you stress. Stress is the actual response to one or a combination of those stressors.

There are any numbers of situations that can cause stress. Dr. Gary Brown, a licensed psychotherapist, says some of the more common stressors include:

- relationship conflicts at home
- new or increasing work responsibilities
- increasing demands
- financial strain
- loss of a loved one

- health problems
- moving to a new location
- exposure to one or more traumatic incidents, such as a car accident or a violent crime
- Knowing how to spot the signs of stress is the first step in developing ways to manage its adverse effects.

Some of the more common physical, psychological, and emotional signs of chronic stress include:

- rapid heart rate
- elevated blood pressure
- feeling overwhelmed
- fatigue
- difficulty sleeping
- poor problem-solving
- fear that the stressor won't go away
- persistent thoughts about one or more stressors
- changes in behavior, including social withdrawal, feelings of sadness, frustration, loss of emotional control, inability to rest, and self-medication

Symptoms of Stress

Physical symptoms of stress include: Low energy. Headaches. Upset stomach, including diarrhea, constipation, and nausea. Aches, pains, and tense muscles. Chest pain and rapid heartbeat. Insomnia. Frequent colds and infections.

Symptoms of stress

Although we all experience stress differently, some common symptoms include:

- Difficulty sleeping;
- Weight gain or weight loss;
- Stomach pain;
- Irritability;
- Teeth grinding;
- Panic attacks;
- Headaches;
- Difficulty concentrating;
- Sweaty hands or feet;
- Heartburn;
- Excessive sleeping;
- Social isolation;
- Fatigue;

- Nausea;
- Feeling overwhelmed;
- and obsessive or compulsive behaviors.

Emotional symptoms of stress include:

- Becoming easily agitated, frustrated, and moody
- Feeling overwhelmed, like you are losing control or need to take control
- Having difficulty relaxing and quieting your mind
- Feeling bad about yourself (low self-esteem), lonely, worthless, and depressed
- Avoiding others

Physical symptoms of stress include:

- Low energy
- Headaches
- Upset stomach, including diarrhea, constipation, and nausea
- Aches, pains, and tense muscles
- Chest pain and rapid heartbeat
- Insomnia
- Frequent colds and infections
- Loss of sexual desire and/or ability
- Nervousness and shaking, ringing in the ear, cold or sweaty hands and feet
- Dry mouth and difficulty swallowing
- Clenched jaw and grinding teeth

Cognitive symptoms of stress include:

- Constant worrying
- Racing thoughts
- Forgetfulness and disorganization
- Inability to focus
- Poor judgment
- Being pessimistic or seeing only the negative side

Behavioral symptoms of stress include:

- Changes in appetite -- either not eating or eating too much
- Procrastinating and avoiding responsibilities
- Increased use of alcohol, drugs, or cigarettes
- Exhibiting more nervous behaviors, such as nail biting, fidgeting, and pacing

What Are the Consequences of Long-Term Stress?

A little stress every now and then is not something to be concerned about. Ongoing, chronic stress, however, can cause or exacerbate many serious health problems, including:

- Mental health problems, such as depression, anxiety, and personality disorders
- Cardiovascular disease, including heart disease, high blood pressure, abnormal heart rhythms, heart attacks, and stroke
- Obesity and other eating disorders
- Menstrual problems
- Sexual dysfunction, such as impotence and premature ejaculation in men and loss of sexual desire in both men and women
- Skin and hair problems, such as acne, psoriasis, and eczema, and permanent hair loss
- Gastrointestinal problems, such as GERD, gastritis, ulcerative colitis, and irritable colon

Help Is Available for Stress

Stress is a part of life. What matters most is how you handle it. The best thing you can do to prevent stress overload and the health consequences that come with it is to know your stress symptoms.

If you or a loved one is feeling overwhelmed by stress, talk to your doctor. Many symptoms of stress can also be signs of other health problems. Your doctor can evaluate your symptoms and rule out other conditions. If stress is to blame, your doctor can recommend a therapist or counselor to help you better handle your stress.

Tips for Stress Management

Before discussing stress management techniques, there are several factors to consider.

The following 7 tips are adapted from The American Psychological Association to support individuals with a stress management plan:

1. Understand your stress

How do you stress? It can be different for everybody. By understanding what stress looks like for you, you can be better prepared, and reach for your stress management toolbox when needed.

2. Identify your stress sources

What causes you to be stressed? Be it work, family, change or any of the other potential thousand triggers.

3. Learn to recognize stress signals

We all process stress differently so it's important to be aware of your individual stress symptoms. What are your internal alarm bells? Low tolerance, headaches, stomach pains or a combination from the above 'Symptoms of stress'.

4. Recognize your stress strategies

What is your go-to tactic for calming down? These can be behaviors learned over years and sometimes aren't the healthy option. For example, some people cope with stress by self-medicating with alcohol or overeating.

5. Implement healthy stress management strategies

It's good to be mindful of any current unhealthy coping behaviors so you can switch them out for a healthy option. For example, if overeating is your current go to, you could practice meditation instead, or make a decision to phone a friend to chat through your situation. The American Psychological Association suggests that switching out one behavior at a time is most effective in creating positive change.

6. Make self-care a priority

When we make time for ourselves, we put our well-being before others. This can feel selfish to start, but it is like the airplane analogy—we must put our own oxygen mask on before we can assist others. The simplest things that promote well-being, such as enough sleep, food, downtime, and exercise are often the ones overlooked.

7. Ask for support when needed

If you're feeling overwhelmed, reach out to a friend or family member you can talk to. Speaking with a healthcare professional can also reduce stress, and help us learn healthier coping strategies.

For more tips about stress management check out these renowned books.

Different Stress Management Techniques & Strategies

62 Stress Management Techniques & Tips To Prevent A Burnout

These tips are things we can all benefit from doing more of. The techniques are categorized into three groups:

1. Action Orientated Approaches: used to take action to change a stressful situation
2. Emotion-oriented approaches: used to change the way we perceive a stressful situation
3. Acceptance-oriented approaches: used for dealing with stressful situations you can't control

Explore the below options and find what combination works best for keeping your stress levels under control.

CRISIS MANAGEMENT

What is Crisis Management?

In any organization or business, it is always essential that you are prepared for any problems that may arise when it is least expected.

It is in the way that you deal with these issues that the success of your business will be based on. It is a well known fact that the biggest blow to an organization comes from the major unpredictable disasters that occur often leaving everyone, from the management to the public, involved in a state of confusion.

No organization however big or famous is immune from various crises. This may include situations such as your computer systems failing or even worse, infrastructure being completely destroyed.

Crisis management has entered the field of management only very recently but has since contributed a great deal to the prevention of major management disasters.

Understanding a Crisis

What crisis management typically requires is that you carry out forecasting of certain crises that you think could occur in the near future, putting your organization into jeopardy.

You then also come up with a solution as to how you would go about dealing with such a crisis. This would also require you to have a clear plan of all steps that would need to be taken should such a situation arise.

However, it may not always be the case that the organization has time to prepare for such a crisis. In such a situation, the management team would need to work on mitigating the amount of loss caused and recovering from the crisis at hand.

Types of Crises

It is important that you have a good understanding of the different types of crises that could take place at the very outset.

This is vital as all crises cannot be handled in the same manner and would require different approaches and various techniques to be applied. Although types of crises can be categorized into several kinds, the most common categories are as follows:

- Financial crises - This would be a huge problem for any organization, but is fairly predictable to quite an extent when compared with other types of crises. Such a crisis would basically involve the organization heading in the direction of bankruptcy.
- Natural disasters - This type of crisis is highly unpredictable and could come by at any time. Several examples of such situations could be given today, from example, earthquakes in countries such as China a few years ago and Haiti and other disasters such as tsunamis and hurricanes, you should always be ready to face such a situation.

- **Technological crises** - This is where a system collapses due to failure in the functioning of different equipment and machinery used. As mentioned previously, a computer system failure is one example of such a crisis. These crises could occur either because of human error or a fault in the system used which has multiple consequences. This may also include chemical spills and oil leaks. One famous case is that of the Chernobyl nuclear power plant in 1986 which caused much damage.
- **Political & Social** - With the current political climate the world over, you may also want to take into consideration any threats to security and any form of terrorist activity.

No organization is free from internal politics and disagreement between the various levels of the workforce.

It is therefore essential that you always keep in mind that high-ranking workers could always resign in the middle of an important project or the workers may plan a strike or protest to express their disgruntlement with the way certain aspects of the organization are run.

Knowing how to manage employee disgruntlement is therefore key to preventing any future fights from erupting, impeding the progress of work being carried out by the organization.

Planning for an Impending Crisis

Without a clear plan as to how to deal with the crises that could occur at the very outset, you would only drag the organization into greater problems.

It is very important that someone plays the role of a leader and chooses a dynamic team in order to carry out all aspects of planning.

It is this management team that would have to not only ascertain what types of crises may occur, but then carry on to study various strategies that could be applied to minimize or even prevent altogether any damage that could be caused.

The next step would then be to try out these strategies and see if it would work.

At times such as these, your organization would benefit greatly from other organizations that would be able to provide you with invaluable resources to help you mitigate the crises to the greatest extent possible.



Leadership framework for crisis management

Dealing with Crises

It is essential to keep in mind that when a crisis occurs you would need to have a response team ready to deal with the media and the various stakeholders.

All these parties would need information on the given situation and what is being done to deal with it. This also requires you to have a clear crisis communication plan with the target audience in mind.

Remember that each group needs to be handled in a different manner; customers may not require the same information as the employees of the organization, and so on.

Conclusion

The only way to successfully control a crisis from going out of your hands is to always have a good plan and a good team ready to deal with various situations that may crop up.

With these strategies in place, you would always be able to reduce the damage caused to the organization to a great extent.